

SUPERNOVAE

The brightest
supernova, ASASSN-
15lh, outshone
the Sun 570
billion times.



A lightweight star like the Sun dies quietly, puffing off its outer layers in a glowing cloud (a planetary nebula). But a heavyweight star suffers a spectacular death. As its iron core collapses, numerous tiny particles, called neutrinos, flood out, blasting the star apart in a dazzling supernova explosion.

DATA FILE



FIRST RECORDED: 185 CE, by Chinese astronomers



MOST RECENT NAKED-EYE SUPERNOVA: SN1987A, in 1987



NEAREST OBSERVED SUPERNOVA: SN1054 (created the Crab Nebula)



MOST PROLIFIC DISCOVERER: Tom Boles, UK, 155 supernovae